

Philosophy & Ethics

27 questions for explanation, comparison, application, and evaluation.

Original study prompts, not official exam-board questions, predictions, or a mark scheme. Choose questions that fit your course and your teacher's guidance.

Natural Law

01. How far can an account of human purposes justify Aquinas's primary precepts? Explain the link and assess one serious objection.
02. Does natural law offer clearer guidance than situation ethics when duties appear to conflict? Develop and test a comparison.
03. A person tells a lie to protect someone from an unjust threat. Can a natural-law approach distinguish a good intention from a justified action?

Situation Ethics

04. Can agape provide a sufficiently clear standard for moral judgement? Explain Fletcher's approach and consider the strongest challenge to it.
05. Is situation ethics meaningfully different from utilitarianism? Assess the importance of their accounts of the good, not just their attention to outcomes.
06. Keeping a promise would cause avoidable harm, but breaking it would damage trust. How could a situation ethicist reach and defend a decision?

Kantian Ethics

07. Does the distinction between acting from duty and acting in accordance with duty give a convincing account of moral worth?
08. Which offers a stronger protection against exploitation: Kant's formula of humanity or rule utilitarianism? Explain and assess a difficult case.
09. A seller hides an important defect because disclosure would reduce profit. Formulate the maxim and evaluate it using two formulations of the Categorical Imperative.

A productive first step

Define the dispute. Write a provisional judgement and one reason. Test the strongest objection; refine or change your position if it succeeds. For timed work, follow your teacher's timing and assessment guidance.

Practice questions

Develop a reasoned answer. A different conclusion can be strong if it is well supported.

Utilitarianism

10. Does Mill's distinction between higher and lower pleasures improve on a purely quantitative account of happiness? Give reasons for your judgement.
11. Does rule utilitarianism answer the objection that act utilitarianism can sacrifice individuals unfairly? Consider both the reply and its costs.
12. A community must choose between a popular short-term benefit and a less popular long-term benefit. What makes the utilitarian comparison difficult, and can those difficulties be overcome?

Euthanasia

13. How should an ethical argument about voluntary euthanasia weigh autonomy against the value of life? Define the practice precisely and assess a counterargument.
14. Do natural law and situation ethics disagree about euthanasia because of different moral principles, different assumptions about cases, or both?
15. Does the distinction between intending death and foreseeing death settle the moral debate about end-of-life decisions? Explain its role and test its limits.

Business Ethics

16. Can a business justify decisions solely by their contribution to profit? Assess the strongest argument for this view and a serious objection.
17. Would a Kantian or a utilitarian approach give a more convincing account of a company's responsibilities to workers and customers?
18. A company can cut costs by concealing a risk from customers. Evaluate the decision without assuming that legality and morality are the same.

Handle applied questions carefully

Define the relevant practice and distinguish principles from assumptions about a case. These prompts support philosophical analysis, not medical or legal advice. Avoid treating legality, popularity, or sincerity as proof of moral rightness.

Practice questions

Develop a reasoned answer. A different conclusion can be strong if it is well supported.

Metaethics

19. Does persistent moral disagreement show that moral judgements cannot be objectively true? Distinguish the claim from the argument offered for it.
20. Does cognitivism or non-cognitivism better explain what speakers are doing when they disagree about whether an action is wrong?
21. Someone argues that an action is morally good because it is natural. What additional premise would the argument need, and could that premise be justified?

Conscience

22. Does a sincere judgement of conscience give a person a sufficient reason to act? Explain why sincerity and reliability might come apart.
23. Can an account of conscience as rational moral judgement coexist with a psychological explanation of how it develops? Explain and evaluate the possible tension.
24. Two informed people appeal to conscience to defend opposite decisions. What further reasons would help assess their claims without simply assuming one is correct?

Sexual Ethics

25. Is freely given, informed consent sufficient for an ethical sexual relationship, or are further considerations needed? Explain and assess your criteria.
26. How do natural law and situation ethics justify their standards for sexual relationships? Compare their reasoning while representing those affected with respect.
27. Should moral judgements about relationships distinguish personal disapproval, harm, and rights? Explain why the distinctions matter and assess a possible objection.

Self-review: reasons, not a grade calculator

Focus: Have I defined the disputed terms and answered this question?

Understanding: Have I represented the relevant thinkers accurately and checked my sources?

Analysis: Have I explained how each reason supports the conclusion?

Evaluation: Have I tested a serious objection and the best available response?

Judgement: Have I justified my conclusion and acknowledged its limits?